

Frontend Interview Handbook — Part 9: Behavioral, Company Fit & Mock Interview

SECTION A: THE STAR FRAMEWORK

Q1: What is STAR, and why do interviewers insist on it even when candidates find it stiff?

Answer: Situation (brief context), Task (what you were responsible for), Action (specifically what *you* did — not "we," you), Result (outcome, ideally quantified). Interviewers use it because vague answers ("I'm good at teamwork") are unfalsifiable and hard to evaluate — a concrete story with a specific action and result is verifiable evidence of how you actually behave under real conditions. Keep each answer to ~90 seconds; going much longer loses the interviewer's attention and dilutes the point.

Practical tip: Prepare 5-6 flexible stories, not 15 rigid ones — most behavioral questions can be answered by adapting one of a handful of strong stories to the specific question asked, rather than needing a completely separate story for each possible prompt.

SECTION B: YOUR STAR STORIES, FULLY WORKED (fill in bracketed specifics with real numbers before the interview)

Story 1 — Technical ownership / AI feature (SEOP)

Likely questions this answers: "Tell me about a technical challenge you solved," "Describe a project you're proud of," "Tell me about a time you worked with a new/unfamiliar technology."

Situation: SEOP is a multi-tenant B2B SaaS platform for operations and inventory management. One recurring pain point for users was slow, manual supplier sourcing during the RFQ (request-for-quote) process.

Task: I was responsible for adding AI-assisted supplier search and email composition to speed up sourcing.

Action: [Fill in: what model/API did you integrate — OpenAI, another provider? How did you structure the prompt/request from the frontend? How did you handle latency — did you show a loading/streaming state? How did you handle failures — fallback to manual search? Did you validate/sanitize AI output before showing it to users?]

Result: [Fill in: quantify if possible — time saved per RFQ, adoption rate, user feedback. If you don't have hard numbers, describe the qualitative before/after clearly.]

Story 2 — Frontend/UX improvement with measurable impact (Rentmann Properties)

Likely questions this answers: "Tell me about a time you improved something," "Describe your approach to UX," "Tell me about working with APIs."

Situation: Rentmann Properties needed a more engaging, accessible property listing platform.

Task: Build responsive interfaces and integrate real-time data from the Django backend.

Action: [Fill in: specific components you built, specific accessibility/responsiveness decisions you made, how you structured the API integration.]

Result: [Fill in: "improved user engagement" — with what specific metric or observed behavior change?]

Story 3 — End-to-end delivery under real constraints (SIP Consult — hotel system)

Likely questions this answers: "Tell me about a large project you delivered," "Describe working with a client directly," "Tell me about handling reporting/data-heavy features."

Situation: Frankie's Hotel needed a full reservation, billing, and audit system.

Task: Build the platform end-to-end and build reporting dashboards using DevExpress/SQL.

Action: [Fill in: how did you structure the reservation/billing data model? What made the reporting genuinely useful — what specific reports did you build? How did you handle real-time updates across modules — polling? WebSockets? Refetch on action?]

Result: Streamlined operations, improved transparency via audit trails. [Add a concrete example: a specific problem the audit trail caught, or specific time savings for hotel staff.]

Story 4 — Leadership/ownership without close oversight (SEOP or JEAB)

Likely questions this answers: "Tell me about a time you led something," "Describe working independently," "Tell me about navigating ambiguity."

For SEOP: You *led the development* of a multi-tenant B2B SaaS platform — this is a strong "ownership" story. Be ready to describe specific decisions you made without being told exactly what to do (architecture choices, feature prioritization, how you decided the RBAC model).

For JEAB (Logistics Manager/IT Lead): A genuinely good "operating in ambiguity/non-software domain" story — negotiating with international distributors, managing supply chain for major clients (Zijin Mine, Jordi Drilling). Interviewers like a candidate who's operated in a completely different domain under real business pressure — it signals adaptability more than another software story would.

Story 5 — A time something went wrong / a mistake

Likely questions this answers: "Tell me about a failure," "Describe a time you were wrong," "Tell me about a bug that made it to production."

Important: This story is *not optional* to skip — interviewers specifically probe for self-awareness here, and "I can't think of a failure" reads as either dishonest or lacking reflection. Prepare one honestly: a bug you shipped, a technical decision you'd reverse in hindsight, a time you underestimated scope. Focus more time on **what you learned and changed afterward** than on the mistake itself.

Action item: Write this one out fully — it's the one most candidates skip preparing and then fumble live.

Story 6 — Cross-functional/client communication

Likely questions this answers: "Tell me about working with non-technical stakeholders," "Describe handling a disagreement with a client/PM."

Your CV mentions leading client demos and refining requirements at Rentmann — build this out with a specific example of a requirement that changed after stakeholder input, and how you handled the resulting rework.

SECTION C: COMPANY FIT — VIEWENGINE SPECIFIC

Q2: "Why ViewEngine? Why this role?"

Strong answer framework: Connect three things explicitly — (1) your full-stack background (Django/DRF + React) matches their need for engineers who understand both the API/data layer and the rendering layer that determines search/AI visibility, (2) you're drawn to a boutique/high-ownership environment based on your track record of leading projects solo (SEOP), not needing heavy oversight, and (3) something genuine and specific about GEO/AEO being a newer, fast-evolving space you're interested in growing expertise in — not generic "I love your mission" language.

Avoid: Generic answers that could apply to any company ("I want to grow my skills," "I love a fast-paced environment") — these signal you didn't research them specifically.

Q3: "What do you know about what we do?"

Strong answer: Be able to state it back in your own words, specifically: ViewEngine helps brands (enterprises, franchises, service companies, B2B SaaS) get found where their customers actually search now — not just Google, but AI answer engines like ChatGPT, Perplexity, and Google AI Overviews — through AEO/GEO, programmatic SEO, and custom tooling when off-the-shelf tools don't fit. Mentioning the "11x traffic in under 4

months" type of outcome (if accurate/current — verify before quoting) shows you actually read their materials, not just skimmed the company name.

Q4: "This is a small/boutique team — how do you operate without a lot of process or oversight?"

Strong answer: Point directly at SEOP — you led development of a multi-tenant SaaS platform, made real architectural and prioritization decisions, and didn't have a large team structure dictating every step. Contrast briefly with SIP Consult/Rentmann where you operated within more defined client requirements — shows you can do both, but have direct evidence of thriving with ownership.

SECTION D: OTHER COMMON BEHAVIORAL QUESTIONS

- **"Why are you leaving/why did you leave [previous role]?"** — Keep neutral and forward-looking; never speak negatively about a past employer. Frame in terms of what you're moving toward, not what you're escaping.
 - **"How do you handle disagreement with a teammate or manager?"** — Emphasize bringing data/reasoning, listening to the other side, and that you can disagree-and-commit when needed.
 - **"How do you prioritize when everything feels urgent?"** — Concrete framework beats vague answer: impact vs effort, checking with stakeholders on true deadlines, communicating tradeoffs rather than silently dropping something.
 - **"Tell me about a time you had to learn something quickly."** — Given your AWS certifications and range of tools (Django→React→AWS→AI tools), you have strong raw material here — pick one specific instance, not a general "I learn fast" claim.
 - **"How do you use AI coding tools (Claude Code, Copilot, DeepSeek, Lovable) in your day-to-day work?"** — Be specific and honest: where they save real time (boilerplate, scaffolding, exploring unfamiliar APIs, generating test cases) and where you still do the thinking yourself (architecture decisions, reviewing generated code before shipping it, correctness-critical logic). A company doing technical/AI-adjacent work will want confidence you're not just shipping unreviewed AI output.
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SECTION E: QUESTIONS TO ASK THE INTERVIEWER

Pick 2-3, not all — asking too many can eat time better spent elsewhere.

About the role/team:

- "What does the frontend architecture look like today — is it Next.js already, and if so App Router or Pages Router?"
- "How much overlap is there day-to-day between frontend engineering and the SEO/GEO strategy side of the business?"

About the business:

- "How do you currently measure whether a GEO/AEO change actually improved visibility in AI answer engines — is there reliable tooling for that yet, given how new the space is?"
- "What's the biggest technical challenge in scaling programmatic SEO content without it becoming thin/low-quality?"

About growth/expectations:

- "What would success look like in this role at the 3-month and 6-month mark?"

SECTION F: MOCK INTERVIEW — SAMPLE FLOW

Use this as a script to rehearse out loud, ideally recording yourself once.

Interviewer: "Walk me through your background." → *90-second summary: full-stack engineer, 3+ years, Django/DRF + React/TypeScript, AWS-certified, led development of a multi-tenant SaaS platform, now focused on frontend with strong backend fluency as a differentiator.*

Interviewer: "Why frontend, given how full-stack your background is?" → *Use the Q6 answer from Part 3/6 area — depth over breadth, but backend fluency makes you a stronger frontend engineer, not a compromise.*

Interviewer: "Let's do some code — can you write a debounce function and explain when you'd use it?" → *Write it, narrate while coding, connect to a real use case (search-as-you-type from your own project experience).*

Interviewer: "Why does client-side-only rendering hurt SEO?" → *This is the single question you should be able to answer flawlessly without hesitation — see Part 3, Q2.*

Interviewer: "Tell me about a time you disagreed with a technical decision." → *STAR story, ~90 seconds, specific action and result.*

Interviewer: "Any questions for me?" → *2-3 from Section E above, chosen based on what actually came up in conversation.*

End of Part 9. Say "next part" for Part 10: Rapid Revision — 100 Most Likely Questions (final part).